Bill's Helix Cheat Sheet / Command Reference

1 Introduction

- Document version: 1.0.0-beta, April-2026
- Based on Helix version: 25.07.1.
- Distributed at: https://github.com/wrwetzel/Helix-Cheat-Sheet
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1.1 Definitions

- **file** - the actual data on storage device
- **buffers** - data from one or more files loaded into memory
- **view** - one or more visual areas on screen showing one or more buffers
- **workspace** - the directory from which Helix was launched
- **under selection** - the entire word containing the cursor, not just the selection
- **alternate buffer** - the previous active buffer
- **textual line** - text as defined by the newline character
- **visual line** - what appears on screen after word-wrapping

1.2 Typographic Conventions

- **`word`** - alphanumeric, punctuation-delimited
- **`WORD`** - whitespace-delimited
- **`Ctrl-c`** - Ctrl and c key pressed simultaneous.
- **`Alt-c`** - Alt and c key pressed simultaneous.
- Some Alt and Ctrl characters may conflict with terminal capture and require terminal configuration change.
- **`␣c`** is space followed by the character c.
- Metavars **`<regex>`**, **`<file>`** and **`<ch>`** represent user input. The angle-brackets are not part of the input.
- **`␣`**, **`<minus>`**, and **`<under>`** used for clarity. **`<enter>`**, **`<del>`**, **`<bksp>`**, etc. used for non-printing control characters.
- Commands are separated from definitions by a dash. Synonyms are separated by commas. Related commands are separated by slashes. The separators are never part of the command though commands may include a dash, comma, or slash.

1.3 Launching

- **`helix`**
- **`helix`** `<file>`
- **`helix`** `<file1> <file2> … <filen>`
- **`helix`** `–help`
- **`hx`** `in some distributions or by alias`

1.4 Basics

Editing paradigm: select first, action second. *mode* and *count* are optional.

```
[mode][count][select][command]
```

1.4.1 Example

```
v3wd
          v – enter select mode
          3 – select 3
          w – words
          d – delete
```

1.4.2 Samples

```
         wd – delete word
         xc – change line
         %y – yank entire file
```

1.5 Modes

As used in Helix documentation.

```
          : – command
          i – insert
          v – select or extend
          z – view - change view preserving selection
          g – goto
          m – match
     Ctrl-w – window
          ␣ – space
       [, ] – unimpaired
```

2 Primary Commands

2.1 Essentials

```
      u / U – undo / redo change in linear history
   Alt-u / – move backward / forward in tree history
     Alt-U
:ear / :lat – move backward / forward in history by
              step count or time span (1s, 2m, 3h, 4d)
  <nn><cmd> – repeat <cmd> <nn> times
        Esc – return to normal mode
```

2.1.1 Quit

Add **!** suffix to force operation.

```
        :wq – write current buffer and quit
  :wq <file> – write current buffer to <file> and quit
       :wqa – write all buffer(s) and quit
         :q – quit current buffer, exits if last
```

2.1.2 Files

```
   :o <file> – open <file> in new buffer
   :w <file> – write current buffer to <file>

  :hs <file> – open/create <file> in new horizontal split
  :vs <file> – open/create <file> in new vertical split
         ␣wf – open/create file(s) under selection(s) in
               horizontal split
         ␣wF – open/create file(s) under selection(s) in
               vertical split
          gf – open/create file(s) under selection, open
               url under selection.

          ␣f – open file picker at LSP workspace root
          ␣F – open file picker at current working
               directory
          ␣g – open changed file picker
```

2.1.2.1 File Picker

All pickers, here and elsewhere, are *fuzzy* - they tolerate gaps in the input, ranking closer matches higher.

```
     <enter> – open selected in current view
      Ctrl-s – open selected in new horizontal split
      Ctrl-v – open selected in new vertical split
```

2.1.3 Buffers

Add **!** suffix to force operation. Buffers named by file they contain.

```
          :n – create new scratch buffer
         :bc – close current buffer
        :bca – close all buffers
        :bco – close all but current buffer
         :bn – next buffer
          ␣b – open buffer picker

          ga – go to last accessed/alternate buffer
          gm – go to last modified/alternate buffer
          gn – go to next buffer
          gp – go to previous buffer
```

2.1.4 Views

Ctrl-w and **␣w** are synonymous.

```
  ␣ws / ␣wv  – split horizontal / vertical, current buffer
      ␣wns / – split horizontal / vertical, new buffer
        ␣wnv
         ␣wq – close current split
         ␣wo – close all but current split
         ␣ww – next split

  ␣wh/j/k/l – move to buffer left / up / down / right
  ␣wH/J/K/L – swap split with buffer on left / up /
              down / right
         ␣wt – transpose split
```

2.1.4.1 View Movement

Commands shown with **z** prefix. The prefix is not used in sticky mode, which is a view-only navigation mode appropriate for browsing a file without editing.

```
          Z – enter sticky mode, exit with Esc

     zz, zc – align to center
         zt – align to top
         zb – align to bottom
         zm – align to middle horizontally
         zj – scroll down
         zk – scroll up
```

2.1.5 Help

```
     :tutor – open tutorial
         ␣? – open command palette
```

2.2 Movement

2.2.1 Cursor Movement

Normal Mode: motion replaces selection
Select Mode: motion extends selection

```
       h/j/k/l – left / up / down / right
        gh, g| – beginning of line
        <nn>g| – column <nn>
            gl – end of line
            gg – top of file
<nn>G, g<nn>g – line <nn>
            ge – bottom of file
            gw – two-char labels on words, label to go
                 to word

            g.– to last modification in current file
            gj – down textual line
            gk – up textual line

            gs – first non-white-space char
            gt – top of screen
            gc – middle of screen
            gb – bottom of screen
```

2.2.2 By Language Server Protocol - Semantics

Requires LSP support.

```
gd – go to definition
gy – go to type definition
gr – go to references
gi – go to implementation

]d – next diagnostic
[d – prior diagnostic
]D – last diagnostic
[D – first diagnostic
```

2.2.3 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

```
]f, [f – to next, prior function
]t, [t – to next, prior type definition
]T, [T – to next, prior test
]a, [a – to next, prior arg
]c, [c – to next, prior comment
]g, [g – to next, prior change
]G, [G – to last, first change

Alt-e – move to end of parent node in syntax
        tree
Alt-b – move to start of parent node in syntax
        tree
```

2.2.4 By Page

```
Ctrl-b – page up
Ctrl-f – page down
Ctrl-u – half page up
Ctrl-d – half page down
```

2.3 Selection

Selection: a range of characters between anchor and cursor
Normal Mode: move and select
Select Mode: move and extend selection

2.3.1 Operations

```
%  – select whole file
Alt-; – swap anchor and cursor
Alt-: – selection to normal direction (cursor at
        end)
Alt-o – expand selection syntax-aware
Alt-i – shrink selection
;  – collapse selection(s) to cursor(s)
```

2.3.2 By TextObjects

```
ma<ch> / mi<ch> – match around / inside the object
                  indicated by <ch> below:

w / W – word / WORD
p – paragraph
(, [, ', etc.– specified surround pairs
m –  closest surround pair
f – function
t – type or class
a – argument/parameter
c – comment
T – test
g – change git hunk
```

2.3.3 By Syntactic Objects

```
w / W – to start of next word / WORD
e / E – to end of current word / WORD
b / B – to start of current word / WORD
x – current line, extend by line
X – extend to line
Alt-x – shrink to line bounds
]p – to next paragraph
[p – to prior paragraph
```

2.3.4 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

```
Alt-o – expand selection to parent syntax node
Alt-i – shrink syntax tree object selection
Alt-p – select previous sibling node in syntax
        tree
Alt-n – select next sibling node in syntax tree
Alt-a – select all sibling nodes in syntax tree
Alt-I – select all children nodes in syntax tree
```

2.3.5 By Character Value

Lower case: forward
Upper case: backward

```
f<ch>, F<ch> – to <ch> inclusive (find)
t<ch>, T<ch> – to <ch> exclusive (till)
Alt-.  – repeat last find / till
```

2.4 Select Mode

Movement: extends selection
Search: adds to selection

```
v – toggle select mode
Esc – return to normal
) – cycle primary selection forward
( – cycle primary selection backward
Alt-,  – remove primary selection
```

2.5 Multiple Selections

Multiple independent cursors / selections, one is *primary*.

2.5.1 Creating

Create multiple selections from selection.

```
s<regex> – matches become selections
S – split on match
Alt-s – split on newlines
C, Alt-C – add selection below, above
```

2.5.2 Operations

```
&  – align on primary cursor
Alt-<minus> – merge selections
Alt-<under> – merge consecutive selections
,  – remove all except primary selection
Alt-,  – remove primary selection
( / ) – rotate primary backwards / forwards
Alt-( / – rotate content backward / forward
Alt-)
K – keep selections matching the regex
Alt-K – remove selections matching the regex
```

2.6 Alter Buffer Content

2.6.1 Insert

```
      i – before selection
      a – after selection
      I – at start of line
      A – at end of line
      o – add line and insert below cursor
      O – add line and insert above cursor
    Esc – end insert (return to normal)
      . – repeat last insert
```

2.6.2 Add

```
     ]␣ – newline below
     [␣ – newline above
  ms<ch> – add delim <ch> around selection
```

2.6.3 Delete

```
      d – selection -> yank buf, delete selection
  Alt-d – delete, no save
  md<ch> – delete delim <ch> around selection
```

2.6.4 Change

```
      c – selection -> yank buf, change selection
  Alt-c – change, no save
      = – format by LSP
mr<ch1><ch2> – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2>
```

2.6.5 Indent Lines

```
      > – Indent line(s) containing selection
      < – Undent line(s) containing selection
```

2.6.6 Change Case

Change case of all letters in selection

```
      ~ – change case
      ` – set lowercase
  Alt-` – set uppercase
```

2.6.7 Comments

All apply to selection.

```
  ␣c, Ctrl-c – Toggle comment
         ␣C – Toggle block comment
    ␣Alt-C – Toggle line comment
```

2.6.8 Increment / Decrement

```
  Ctrl-a – increment the selected number
  Ctrl-x – decrement the selected number
```

2.6.9 Miscellaneous

```
      J – join lines in a selection
  Alt-J – join lines inside selection and select the
          inserted space
<under> – trim whitespace from selection
```

2.7 Copy / Paste / Replace

```
      y – selection -> yank buf
      p – paste yank buf after the cursor
      P – paste yank buf before the cursor
     ␣y – yank selection(s) -> system clipboard
     ␣Y – yank main selection -> system clipboard
  ␣p / ␣P – paste clipboard after / before
            selections(s)
     ␣R – replace selection(s) with clipboard
  r<ch> – replace selection with <ch>
      R – replace selection with yank buf
      " – select register to yank to or paste from
```

2.8 Search

```
  /<regex> – search forward for regex
  ?<regex> – search backward for regex
     n, N – next, previous match
        * – search for current selection, respect
            word boundaries
    Alt-* – search for current selection
```

2.9 Registers

Identified by single char <ch>

```
   "<ch> – change to reg <ch>
  "<ch>y – yank into reg <ch>
  "<ch>p – paste from reg <ch>
  "<ch>R – replace with reg <ch>
```

2.10 Macros

```
  "<ch>Q – toggle capture to reg <ch>, default @
  "<ch>q – play macro in reg <ch>, default @
```

2.11 Jumplists

```
  Ctrl-s – save current position to jumplist
  Ctrl-i – move forward in jumplist
  Ctrl-o – move backwards in jumplist
      ␣j – open jumplist picker
```

2.12 Match Mode

With regard to balanced delimiters.

```
      mm – go to matching delim
  mi<ch> – match inside delim <ch>
  ma<ch> – match around delim <ch>
  ms<ch> – add delim <ch> around selection
  md<ch> – delete delim <ch> around selection
mr<ch1><ch2> – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2>
```

2.13 Shell

All commands pipe each selection to shell command.

```
      | – replace selection(s) with output
  Alt-| – ignore output
      ! – insert output before each selection(s)
  Alt-! – append output after each selection(s)
      $ – keep selection(s) where command
          returned 0
```

2.14 Approaching an IDE

`␣G`	– debug - experimental
`␣k`	– show documentation for item under cursor
`␣s`	– open document symbol picker
`␣S`	– open workspace symbol picker
`␣d`	– open document diagnostics picker
`␣D`	– open workspace diagnostics picker
`␣r`	– rename symbol
`␣a`	– apply code action
`␣h`	– select symbol references for symbol under cursor

2.15 Editor Configuration

`:config-open`	– open the config file
`:config-open-workspace`	– open the workspace config file
`:config-reload`	– reload the config file

2.16 Miscellaneous

`␣'`	– open last picker
`␣/`	– open global search in workspace folder picker

3 Commands in Specific Contexts

3.1 Insert Mode Editing

Navigation keys shown.

```
                Ctrl-s – commit undo checkpoint
                Ctrl-x – autocomplete
                Ctrl-r – insert a register content
   Ctrl-w, Alt-<bksp> – delete previous word
     Alt-d, Alt-<del> – delete next word
                Ctrl-u – delete to start of line
                Ctrl-k – delete to end of line
       Ctrl-h, <bksp>,– delete previous char
         Shift-<bksp>
        Ctrl-d, <del> – delete next char
      Ctrl-j, <enter> – insert new line
  <Up> <Down> <Left> – usual meaning but
    <Right> <PageUp>   discouraged
   <PageDown> <Home>
               <End>
```

3.2 Command Line Editing

```
           Esc, Ctrl-c – close prompt
               <enter> – open selected
                 <tab> – select next completion item
             <backtab> – select previous completion
                         item
                 Alt-b – backward a word
                Ctrl-b – backward a char
                 Alt-f – forward a word
                Ctrl-f – forward a char
                Ctrl-e – to prompt end
                Ctrl-a – to prompt start
  Ctrl-w, Ctrl-<bksp> – delete previous word
    Alt-d, Ctrl-<del> – delete next word
                Ctrl-u – delete to start of line
                Ctrl-k – delete to end of line
        <bksp>, Ctrl-h – delete previous char
         <del>, Ctrl-d – delete next char
                Ctrl-s – insert a word under doc
                         cursor (may be changed to
                         Ctrl-r Ctrl-w later)
                Ctrl-p – select previous history
                Ctrl-n – select next history
                Ctrl-r – insert the content of the
                         register selected by
                         following input char
```

3.3 Pickers

Navigation keys shown.

```
  Shift-<tab>, Ctrl-p,– previous entry
                 <Up>
        <tab>, Ctrl-n,– next entry
                <Down>
                <Home> – to first entry
                 <End> – to last entry
     Ctrl-u, <PageUp> – page up
   Ctrl-d, <PageDown> – page down
              <enter> – open selected
          Alt-<enter> – open selected in the
                        background without closing
                        the picker
                Ctrl-s – open horizontally
                Ctrl-v – open vertically
                Ctrl-t – toggle preview
           Esc, Ctrl-c – close picker
```

3.4 Popups

Displays documentation for item under cursor.

```
      Ctrl-u – scroll up
      Ctrl-d – scroll down
```

3.5 Completion Menu

Displays documentation for the selected completion item. Any other keypresses result in the completion being accepted.

```
  Shift-Tab, Ctrl-p – previous entry
        Tab, Ctrl-n – next entry
            <enter> – close menu and accept
                      completion
             Ctrl-c – close menu and reject
                      completion
```

3.6 Signature-help Popup

Displays the signature of the selected completion item.

```
      Alt-p – previous signature
      Alt-n – next signature
```

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- `Ctrl-c` – close prompt **(3.2)**
- `Ctrl-d` – delete next char **(3.1)**
- `Ctrl-d` – delete next char **(3.2)**
- `Ctrl-d` – half page down **(2.2.4)**
- `Ctrl-d` – page down **(3.3)**
- `Ctrl-d` – scroll down **(3.4)**
- `Ctrl-e` – to prompt end **(3.2)**
- `Ctrl-f` – forward a char **(3.2)**
- `Ctrl-f` – page down **(2.2.4)**
- `Ctrl-h` – delete previous char **(3.1)**
- `Ctrl-h` – delete previous char **(3.2)**
- `Ctrl-i` – move forward in jumplist **(2.11)**
- `Ctrl-j` – insert new line **(3.1)**
- `Ctrl-k` – delete to end of line **(3.1)**
- `Ctrl-k` – delete to end of line **(3.2)**
- `Ctrl-n` – next entry **(3.3)**
- `Ctrl-n` – next entry **(3.5)**
- `Ctrl-n` – select next history **(3.2)**
- `Ctrl-o` – move backwards in jumplist **(2.11)**
- `Ctrl-p` – previous entry **(3.3)**
- `Ctrl-p` – previous entry **(3.5)**
- `Ctrl-p` – select previous history **(3.2)**
- `Ctrl-r` – insert a register content **(3.1)**
- `Ctrl-r` – insert the content of the register selected by following input char **(3.2)**
- `Ctrl-s` – commit undo checkpoint **(3.1)**
- `Ctrl-s` – insert a word under doc cursor (may be changed to Ctrl-r Ctrl-w later) **(3.2)**
- `Ctrl-s` – open horizontally **(3.3)**
- `Ctrl-s` – open selected in new horizontal split **(2.1.2.1)**
- `Ctrl-s` – save current position to jumplist **(2.11)**
- `Ctrl-t` – toggle preview **(3.3)**
- `Ctrl-u` – delete to start of line **(3.1)**
- `Ctrl-u` – delete to start of line **(3.2)**
- `Ctrl-u` – half page up **(2.2.4)**
- `Ctrl-u` – page up **(3.3)**
- `Ctrl-u` – scroll up **(3.4)**
- `Ctrl-v` – open selected in new vertical split **(2.1.2.1)**
- `Ctrl-v` – open vertically **(3.3)**
- `Ctrl-w` – delete previous word **(3.1)**
- `Ctrl-w` – delete previous word **(3.2)**
- `Ctrl-x` – autocomplete **(3.1)**
- `Ctrl-x` – decrement the selected number **(2.6.8)**
- `Esc` – close picker **(3.3)**
- `Esc` – close prompt **(3.2)**
- `Esc` – end insert (return to normal) **(2.6.1)**
- `Esc` – return to normal **(2.4)**
- `Esc` – return to normal mode **(2.1)**
- `F<ch>` – to <ch> inclusive (find) **(2.3.5)**
- `I` – at start of line **(2.6.1)**
- `J` – join lines in a selection **(2.6.9)**
- `K` – keep selections matching the regex **(2.5.2)**
- `N` – next, previous match **(2.8)**
- `O` – add line and insert above cursor **(2.6.1)**
- `P` – paste yank buf before the cursor **(2.7)**
- `R` – replace selection with yank buf **(2.7)**
- `S` – split on match **(2.5.1)**
- `Shift-<bksp>` – delete previous char **(3.1)**
- `Shift-<tab>` – previous entry **(3.3)**
- `Shift-Tab` – previous entry **(3.5)**
- `T` – test **(2.3.2)**
- `T<ch>` – to <ch> exclusive (till) **(2.3.5)**
- `Tab` – next entry **(3.5)**
- `X` – extend to line **(2.3.3)**
- `Z` – enter sticky mode, exit with Esc **(2.1.4.1)**
- `[␣` – newline above **(2.6.2)**
- `[` – specified surround pairs **(2.3.2)**
- `[D` – first diagnostic **(2.2.2)**
- `[G` – to last, first change **(2.2.3)**
- `[T` – to next, prior test **(2.2.3)**
- `[a` – to next, prior arg **(2.2.3)**
- `[c` – to next, prior comment **(2.2.3)**
- `[d` – prior diagnostic **(2.2.2)**
- `[f` – to next, prior function **(2.2.3)**
- `[g` – to next, prior change **(2.2.3)**
- `[p` – to prior paragraph **(2.3.3)**
- `[t` – to next, prior type definition **(2.2.3)**
- `]␣` – newline below **(2.6.2)**
- `]D` – last diagnostic **(2.2.2)**
- `]G` – to last, first change **(2.2.3)**
- `]T` – to next, prior test **(2.2.3)**
- `]a` – to next, prior arg **(2.2.3)**
- `]c` – to next, prior comment **(2.2.3)**
- `]d` – next diagnostic **(2.2.2)**
- `]f` – to next, prior function **(2.2.3)**
- `]g` – to next, prior change **(2.2.3)**
- `]p` – to next paragraph **(2.3.3)**
- `]t` – to next, prior type definition **(2.2.3)**
- `` ` `` – set lowercase **(2.6.6)**
- `a` – after selection **(2.6.1)**
- `a` – argument/parameter **(2.3.2)**
- `b / B` – to start of current word / WORD **(2.3.3)**
- `c` – comment **(2.3.2)**

- **c** – selection -> yank buf, change selection **(2.6.4)**
- **d** – selection -> yank buf, delete selection **(2.6.3)**
- **e / E** – to end of current word / WORD **(2.3.3)**
- **etc.** – specified surround pairs **(2.3.2)**
- **f** – function **(2.3.2)**
- **f<ch>** – to <ch> inclusive (find) **(2.3.5)**
- **g** – change git hunk **(2.3.2)**
- **g.** – to last modification in current file **(2.2.1)**
- **g<nn>g** – line <nn> **(2.2.1)**
- **ga** – go to last accessed/alternate buffer **(2.1.3)**
- **gb** – bottom of screen **(2.2.1)**
- **gc** – middle of screen **(2.2.1)**
- **gd** – go to definition **(2.2.2)**
- **ge** – bottom of file **(2.2.1)**
- **gf** – open/create file(s) under selection, open url under selection. **(2.1.2)**
- **gg** – top of file **(2.2.1)**
- **gh** – beginning of line **(2.2.1)**
- **gi** – go to implementation **(2.2.2)**
- **gj** – down textual line **(2.2.1)**
- **gk** – up textual line **(2.2.1)**
- **gl** – end of line **(2.2.1)**
- **gm** – go to last modified/alternate buffer **(2.1.3)**
- **gn** – go to next buffer **(2.1.3)**
- **gp** – go to previous buffer **(2.1.3)**
- **gr** – go to references **(2.2.2)**
- **gs** – first non-white-space char **(2.2.1)**
- **gt** – top of screen **(2.2.1)**
- **gw** – two-char labels on words, label to go to word **(2.2.1)**
- **gy** – go to type definition **(2.2.2)**
- **g|** – beginning of line **(2.2.1)**
- **h/j/k/l** – left / up / down / right **(2.2.1)**
- **i** – before selection **(2.6.1)**
- **m** – closest surround pair **(2.3.2)**
- **ma<ch>** – match around delim <ch> **(2.12)**
- **ma<ch> / mi<ch>** – match around / inside the object indicated by <ch> below: **(2.3.2)**
- **md<ch>** – delete delim <ch> around selection **(2.12)**
- **md<ch>** – delete delim <ch> around selection **(2.6.3)**
- **mi<ch>** – match inside delim <ch> **(2.12)**
- **mm** – go to matching delim **(2.12)**
- **mr<ch1><ch2>** – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2> **(2.12)**
- **mr<ch1><ch2>** – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2> **(2.6.4)**
- **ms<ch>** – add delim <ch> around selection **(2.12)**
- **ms<ch>** – add delim <ch> around selection **(2.6.2)**
- **n** – next, previous match **(2.8)**
- **o** – add line and insert below cursor **(2.6.1)**
- **p** – paragraph **(2.3.2)**
- **p** – paste yank buf after the cursor **(2.7)**
- **r<ch>** – replace selection with <ch> **(2.7)**
- **s<regex>** – matches become selections **(2.5.1)**
- **t** – type or class **(2.3.2)**
- **t<ch>** – to <ch> exclusive (till) **(2.3.5)**
- **u / U** – undo / redo change in linear history **(2.1)**
- **v** – toggle select mode **(2.4)**
- **w / W** – to start of next word / WORD **(2.3.3)**
- **w / W** – word / WORD **(2.3.2)**
- **x** – current line, extend by line **(2.3.3)**
- **y** – selection -> yank buf **(2.7)**
- **zb** – align to bottom **(2.1.4.1)**
- **zc** – align to center **(2.1.4.1)**
- **zj** – scroll down **(2.1.4.1)**
- **zk** – scroll up **(2.1.4.1)**
- **zm** – align to middle horizontally **(2.1.4.1)**
- **zt** – align to top **(2.1.4.1)**
- **zz** – align to center **(2.1.4.1)**
- **|** – replace selection(s) with output **(2.13)**
- **~** – change case **(2.6.6)**